

Babylon

Built c.562 BCE, at its peak Babylon was by far the largest city of its time, with an area of at least 10 square kilometres (3.9 square miles). Set on the Euphrates River, its walls enclosed a densely packed area of shrines, temples, markets and houses, all grouped along grand avenues that were arranged in a grid. The city's Etemenanki Ziggurat (605–562 BCE) is believed to have inspired the biblical Tower of Babel. Part of a religious complex in the centre of the city, it was probably covered in coloured glazed bricks. Seven tiers rose from a square foundation 90-metres (297-ft) on each side, with a temple to the god Marduk at the top.

King Nebuchadnezzar II rebuilt the ziggurat as part of his reconstruction of Babylon in the sixth century BCE. He also built the Hanging Gardens – one of the seven wonders of the ancient world – for his wife, Amytis. The Ishtar Gate (opposite) was the largest and most breathtaking of eight entrances to the city. Finished with blue glazed bricks, it was decorated with reliefs of dragons, lions and young bulls.

